CASE STUDY HANDOUT: The Friday-Night Bug

Background

Shohoj Pay is a 14-month-old Dhaka fintech start-up with 22 employees. It runs a mobile wallet app used by about 150,000 people. On **Saturday at 10:00 a.m.** the company will launch an "Eid Cashback" campaign with its partner, **Meghna Commercial Bank**. The campaign will send an SMS to 200,000 people, a TV advertisement is already booked, and a business journalist and an investor from Singapore have been invited to the 9:00 a.m. launch event.

The CEO, **Mr. Hasan Chowdhury**, has staked the company's reputation on this launch. Last month, in an all-hands meeting, he said: "Don't bring me problems at the last minute. Bring me solutions." The partnership agreement with the bank says that if Shohoj Pay does not launch on the agreed date, the promotional slot is lost and the marketing fee of Tk 15 lakh is non-refundable.

The people

Person	Role and situation at 11:10 p.m. Friday
Rafi Ahmed	Junior backend developer, 8 months in the job, 23 years old. Working late on final tests. He is the one who finds the bug.
Tania Rahman	Team lead. She approved the release in writing on Thursday. Her phone has been off since 9 p.m.; she is at a family wedding in Chattogram. At 8:40 p.m. she wrote "OK" in the team group chat.
Imran Kabir	CTO. Currently on leave in Toronto (it is early afternoon there). His status says "On leave: please do not disturb."
Nusrat Jahan	QA engineer. Last week she opened a ticket: "Occasional odd results in transaction history export." Tania marked it "Low priority: after launch."
Mr. Hasan Chowdhury	CEO. Reachable by phone. Known to react strongly to bad news.
Ms. Farzana Islam	Bank's partnership manager. Will attend the launch at 9 a.m.

What Rafi finds

At 11:10 p.m., while running a final test, Rafi notices something strange. When a user exports their transaction history, the system sometimes returns **another user's last five transactions**, including names, amounts and partly masked phone numbers. In 500 test runs, it happened **3 times**. He suspects a problem with how the system stores temporary data (caching), but he is not sure. The production system uses the same code. He thinks a fix might take 3 to 6 hours, but he has never fixed something like this alone. Nusrat's ticket may be the same problem.

Rafi's thoughts and options

- Tania approved the release, so maybe it is her responsibility.
- He could try to fix it quietly and deploy at 3 a.m. without telling anyone.
- He could send a message to the 40-person team group chat (which includes outside contractors).
- He could phone the CEO and risk his anger, or phone Tania repeatedly until she answers.
- He could email Imran in Toronto, who may not reply for hours.
- He wonders: if I speak up and I am wrong, will I lose my job? If I stay silent and something happens, will I be blamed?

Exhibit A: Rafi's first draft message

Draft in the team group chat (not yet sent)

"bhaiya big problem in payment thing, user data some issue, pls check urgent, may be not good to launch. i dont know exact. sorry"

Decision point

It is **11:25 p.m.** The launch event is in 9 hours and 35 minutes. What should Rafi do in the next 30 minutes? Whom should he contact first, by what channel, and what exactly should he say?

Questions for preparation and discussion

1. **Facts:** What do we know for certain? What do we not know? List the stakeholders and what each one wants.
2. **Problem:** Is this mainly a technical problem, a communication problem, or a decision-rights problem (who is allowed to stop the launch)? Explain.
3. **Options:** List at least four options for Rafi. For each, write the best case, the worst case, and who is affected.
4. **Order and channel:** Whom should Rafi contact first, second and third? Choose phone, message, email or in person, and justify your choice.
5. **Message:** Rewrite Rafi's message for (a) Tania, (b) the CEO, (c) Ms. Farzana of the bank. What changes in each?
6. **Pressure:** Suppose the CEO says: "Launch anyway. We'll fix it on Sunday." What should Rafi say or do now?
7. **Prevention:** What should have happened last week when Nusrat opened her ticket? What should the company change?
8. **Legal and ethical radar:** Without knowing the law yet, list every legal or ethical issue you can suspect (privacy, contract, responsibility, honesty). We will return to this list in later weeks.